



FROM ZERO TO PRO - MODULE 11

Flavor, Seasoning & Menu Development

Move from following recipes to composing dishes by learning to taste, balance, and design.

Weeks 20-21 - watch, study, cook, reflect

By the end of this module

- 1 Season confidently with salt, acid, fat, and heat.
- 2 Diagnose and fix an under-seasoned or unbalanced dish.
- 3 Build flavor with aromatics, herbs, spices, and umami.
- 4 Design a small, coherent multi-course menu.

LESSON 11.1

Salt, Fat, Acid, Heat

Objective: Use the four levers that make food taste good.

Key points

- Salt amplifies flavor; most home cooking is under-salted.
- Fat carries flavor and builds richness and texture.
- Acid brightens and balances; it is the most often missing element.
- Season throughout and taste constantly, not just at the end.

Watch out for

- Salting only at the end instead of in layers.
- Forgetting acid, leaving rich dishes heavy and dull.
- Fearing salt and serving flat food.

LESSON 11.2

Tasting and Adjusting

Objective: Build the habit of tasting and diagnosing a dish.

Key points

- Taste at every stage; the spoon is your most important tool.
- Ask 'what does this need?' and change one thing at a time.
- Flat = salt, heavy = acid, thin = fat/reduction, harsh = time/sweetness.
- Adjusting is a loop: taste, diagnose, adjust, taste again.

Watch out for

- Not tasting until the food is plated.
- Changing several things at once and losing track of cause and effect.
- Over-correcting past the balance point.

LESSON 11.3

Building Flavor Bases and Umami

Objective: Layer aromatics, spices, and umami for depth.

Key points

- Start from a slowly softened aromatic base (mirepoix, sofrito, trinity).
- Toast whole spices and bloom ground spices in fat for more flavor.
- Umami (tomato, mushroom, cheese, soy, fish sauce, stock) adds savory depth.
- Finish with fresh contrast - herbs, acid, crunch.

Watch out for

- Rushing the aromatic base so it never builds flavor.
- Adding spices raw at the end instead of blooming them.
- Relying on salt alone for depth instead of umami.

LESSON 11.4

Menu Development

Objective: Design a small, coherent multi-course menu.

Key points

- Vary richness, texture, temperature, and color across courses.
- Balance a heavy course with a lighter, brighter one.
- Design for logistics - not everything can finish at once.
- Use seasonal, affordable ingredients and write a prep timeline.

Watch out for

- Three rich courses in a row that exhaust the palate.
- A menu where every dish needs the oven at 7:00 sharp.
- Ignoring season and cost, making the meal expensive and flat.

Practice & homework

1

Take one bland dish and fix it using only salt, acid, fat, and heat; document each change.

2

Develop one original dish and write it as a formal recipe card (template provided).

3

Design a three-course menu with a shopping list and timeline.

Watch & learn (free)



Ethan Chlebowski (the 'why' behind cooking)

<https://www.youtube.com/@EthanChlebowski>



Adam Ragusea (practical home technique)

<https://www.youtube.com/@aragusea>



Internet Shaquille (efficiency & fundamentals)

<https://www.youtube.com/@internetshaquille>



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Next up - Module 12: The Professional Kitchen: Line, Plating & Career

FROM ZERO TO PRO - THE SELF-TAUGHT CHEF PROGRAM